

Gretser 1607

Defensio Controversiarum Bellarmini — Felix II and Liberius: recognition legitimates a pope

by Jakob Gretser, S.J. (1562–1625); *Defensio of Bellarmine's Controversies, Tomus II (De Christo et Pontifice Romano)*, Ingolstadt 1609 (= *Opera omnia*, tomus IX)

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- Latin transcribed complete (no elisions) from the page images of the Ingolstadt 1609 edition: cols. 1050–1051 (PDF pp. 576–577), col. 532 (PDF p. 309), and col. 1242 (PDF p. 673). Long-s and u/v normalized, abbreviations silently expanded, original spelling otherwise retained; italics mark the adversaries' quoted words.
- Last Edit: July 15, 2026.
- Version: 1.1 (complete passages)
- Selection pages: Tom. II, cols. 531–532, 1050–1051, 1242

Note on this selection: recognition-legitimation applied to a pope, defended against the Protestant controversialists Whitaker, Sutcliffe, and Junius. Felix II entered by an election Gretser concedes was vitiosus — an Arian-backed intrusion while Liberius lived, which the Roman clergy at first refused under oath (“that, while Liberius lived, they would receive no other” — the acceptance-refusal that kept an intruder from the title). When Liberius fell into the external appearance of heresy, the recognition reversed: Felix “was acknowledged and openly held as legitimate Pontiff,” and “from that time Felix was MADE legitimate Pope... and remained true Pontiff to the end of his life.” Note the complete passage's two-school structure on the privately-heretical pope: those who admit a pope can privately err simply concede Liberius's fall; those who deny it resolve the case entirely in the external forum — a pope can be declared deposed “also on account of the EXTERNAL APPEARANCE of heresy... for men are not bound to, nor can they, search hearts, but him whom they see by external works to be a heretic, they judge simply a heretic.” Either way the title travels with the Church's public recognition: the papal twin of Bellarmine's De Conciliis II.9 rule (“whatever may lie hidden in their hearts”) and a seventeenth-century anticipation of the intention-of-the-elect argument — no interior state, of elector or elect, can defeat the public constitution of the title. Gretser thus witnesses the cause-version of the fact-guarantee two decades before Castro Palao's sanatio. The third passage completes the picture: even the schismatic emperors venerated their antipopes “as Vicars of Christ” — conceding the office itself while mistaking its

occupant — and Junius’s rejoinder (all such witness “must be ascribed to public error and inveterate custom”) is the standing Protestant objection every acceptance-argument must answer, preserved here with Gretser’s riposte. Classification: School 1 (cause; note unassigned).

Cols. 1050–1051 (PDF pp. 576–577) — Felix, Liberius, and Whitaker’s “insoluble knot”

Bellarmino says that Felix was not legitimate Pontiff until the lapse of Liberius. This seems incredible to Junius. *For who would believe, he says, that Liberius either refused, or failed to provide the Roman Church with a Bishop before he fled from the persecuting Constantius?* — and he cites for himself the very ancient author of the *Fasciculus Temporum* (who is all of a hundred and a few years old), by whose testimony he says it is established that Felix was made Roman Bishop with the consent of Liberius. But all the ancients cry out against this: they say Felix was intruded by force and violence by the Arians; and so far does it seem from being the case that Liberius wished a successor to be given him and to abdicate this dignity, that whatever he did may not unreasonably be judged to have been done from the desire of recovering his see; and so little did the Roman clergy at first consent to [Felix], that they bound themselves by oath that, while Liberius lived, they would receive no other.

But from these things Whitaker ties us a knot insoluble — as he himself, at any rate, reckons. For he presses us thus: *The Papists maintain that a Pontiff cannot be deposed except when condemned for heresy in a Council* (I shall not inquire how truly Whitaker asserts this; let Bellarmine be read above, book 2, chapter 30); *but Liberius was deposed; therefore he fell into heresy; therefore our adversary fights with himself*, says the Calvinist, *when he confesses that he was deposed and yet denies that he was a heretic*. I reply: those who maintain that a Pontiff, as a private person, can fall into heresy, and that Liberius did in fact fall into heresy, blow away Whitaker’s objection with a single breath. But those who deny that a Pontiff, even as a private teacher, can incur heresy, and who accordingly free Liberius from every interior act of heresy, will reply that a Pontiff can be deposed — or rather deposed by God, and afterwards judged by the Church, and abdicated, or rather declared abdicated — not only for manifest, true, and real heresy, but also on account of the external appearance of heresy, such as appeared in Liberius on account of the peace made with the Arians, and on account of the subscription against Athanasius, and on account of the two confessions of Faith he subscribed, which lacked the word Homousion and had been drawn up by Arians or semi-Arians, although they contained nothing openly against the orthodox faith. And from this presumption of heresy the Pontificate could deservedly be taken from him, says Bellarmine; for men are not bound to, nor can they, search hearts; but him whom they see by external works to be a heretic, they judge simply a heretic, and condemn as a heretic. And from that time Felix was made legitimate Pope; who not only soon withdrew from the communion of the Arians, but struck their leaders — and among them the Emperor Constantius himself — with anathema: and Felix remained true Pontiff to the end of his life. For when he died, Liberius succeeded again, now changed into another man, having laid aside every guise of heresy which, serving the time, he had put on.

Col. 532 (PDF p. 309) — the Athanasius epistle and Felix's faulty entry

Fourthly, Bellarmine cites St. Athanasius, in the epistle to Pope Felix written in the name of the Synod of Alexandria (it stands in Volume 1 of the Councils, in the Acts of Felix II), where he says: *Thou art Peter, and upon thy foundation the pillars of the Church — that is, the Bishops — are confirmed.* Junius, Sutcliffe, Sibrandus, and Whitaker call the authenticity of this epistle into doubt. But even if it be not clearly ascertained whether this epistle proceeded from Athanasius and the Synod of Alexandria, still the contrary has not yet been demonstrated by anyone: for what Sutcliffe objects — *that this epistle bestows the highest praises on Felix, who, while Liberius lived, was intruded into the Roman see by the Arians* — accomplishes little; for although the entry of Felix was faulty, afterwards nevertheless, when Liberius began to communicate with the Arians, he was acknowledged and openly held as legitimate Pontiff, as we shall see in its proper place. Nor is it an obstacle that this epistle says *appeals from every quarter ought to be made to the Roman Bishop*; for that St. Athanasius was of this mind he taught in fact, when he so often implored the help of the Roman see against his enemies, and by appeal to the supreme Pontiff turned aside the machinations of his adversaries. Nor was the contrary sanctioned in the Nicene Council or the sixth African, as Sutcliffe pretends: of which below, in its proper place.

Col. 1242 (PDF p. 673) — antipopes venerated as Vicars of Christ; Junius's "public error" rejoinder

[The sentence opens on the facing column:] ...he has brought out the eulogies of the apostles(?) of Henry IV, paid to the Roman Church and her prelate: for schism could not expunge every sense of religion from breasts otherwise noble, especially with vexation added, which, as the old saying goes, is wont *to give understanding* to the harder sort. For that Henry and the others acknowledged the supreme and universal power of the Roman Pontiff is clear from this: that against the legitimate Pontiffs with whom they waged their feuds they set up *Antipopes*, whom they venerated as Vicars of Christ. Did not Henry IV, prostrate on the ground, adore his own Guibert?

In the testimony of Henry V, Junius omits what is principal and plucks at what is nothing to the purpose: for Bellarmine wishes to prove from the testimonies of the Emperors that the Roman Pontiff is head of the whole Church and universal pastor; this [Henry] affirms in the most explicit words. Junius, skipping past it, begins to chatter about the imperial consecration and blessing, and in his usual manner brings in ignorant and insipid distinctions about the word *Empire and imperial consecration*. And at last he flees once again *to public error*: and whatever Henry V, Frederick I, and Frederick II wrote or said in praise of the Roman Church and the Pontiff must be ascribed *to public error and inveterate custom*. But if they did or said anything in disparagement of the Roman Church and the Pope, that, for these men, is pure Gospel, sweeter than any honey or honeycomb.